

Lecture 2: What is government? What is politics?

GOVT2305: Federal Government

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0.1 Today

- What is Government? What is politics?
- Discussion: Experiences with Government
- Questions

1. Introduction to Government

1.1 Introduction to Government

To really understand government and politics we first need to know what those things are.

1.2 Introduction Government: Questions to consider

What is government or “The State”?

1.3 A word on words

- Government can mean multiple things

- The specific group of people in charge of...
- The enduring institution or organization we call government

- State has at least three meanings

- International: State = independent country
- United States: State = one of the 50 states
- Political Science: State = government

- Politics

- The process of making collective decisions in the context of the state or government

1.4 What is government?

How can we define government?

- What government does?

1.5 What is government?

How can we define government?

- What government does?

- Then what is politics?

- What makes government unique?

- What does this make politics?

1.6 What government does?

Before stepping on the campus today, what was the last time that politics made a difference in your life?

1.7 What is politics?

- **Expensive or involves large amounts of money**
- **Distant**
- **Involves politicians or campaigns**
- **involves voting or decision making**
- **Involves rights**
- **National borders**

- **Controversial**

1.8 What is politics: State and local (mostly)



Houston Public Works

1.9 What is politics: Federal, state and local



Metro rail

1.10 What is politics: Federal, state and local



HCC Central Campus

1.11 What is politics?

- **Not distant**
- **immediate, right here**
- **touches everything**
- **direct impacts are constant**
- **involves all of us**

- **It can be expensive, but it's not always about money**

1.12 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends

1.13 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends
- Immense power to do incredible harm

1.14 Politics is powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends
- Immense power to do incredible harm

1.15 Politics is powerful

Why does politics have such power to cause harm?

1.16 What does government do?

These are all examples of *collective action*, organized action by a group of people to achieve a common goal.

1.17 What makes government different?

What makes government or The State different from other organizations? Is collective action unique to government?

1.18 Other organizations - Group 1

- Family
 - What does it have in common?
 - What is different?

1.19 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
 - What does it (government) have in common?
 - What is different?

1.20 Other organizations

- Family
- Church

- Community organizations (voluntary)

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.21 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.22 Other organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.23 Other organizations - Group 2

- Organized crime

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.24 Other organizations

- Organized crime
- vigilantes

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.25 Other organizations

- Organized crime
- vigilantes
- terrorists

- What does it have in common?
- What is different?

1.26 Other organizations

- For the Group 1 organizations, how can they enforce their rules?

For the Group 2 organizations, who are they responsible to and how do we view their use of force?

1.27 What is “the state”?

The organized, coercive use of violent force commonly accepted as legitimate

- organized
- Coercive use
- violent force (armed force)
- Legitimacy

1.28 Introduction Government: Questions to consider

What is politics?

1.29 What is politics?

- **Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of...**

1.30 What is politics?

- **Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of...**

The State or government.

1.31 The difference between politics and everything else

These organizations all engage in collective action and collective decision making, but lack one thing the state has:

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)

- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

1.32 The difference between politics and everything else

These organizations all engage in collective action, but lack one thing the state has:

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses - The Market

Coercive use of violent force

1.33 Studying other organizations

Family, church, the market, etc. are all about making collective decisions in:

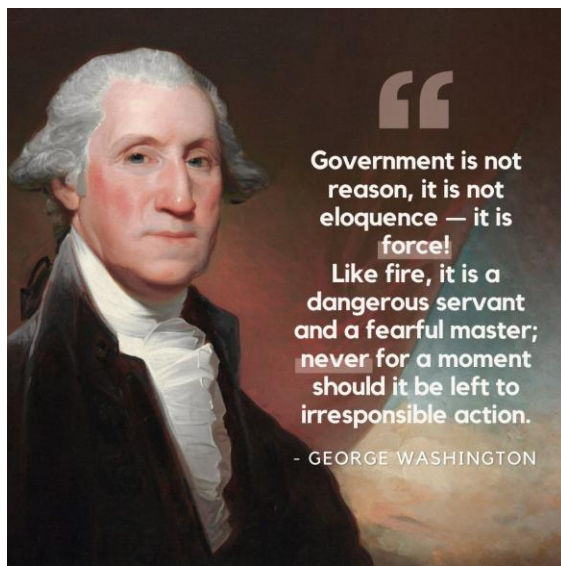
The Voluntary Sphere

1.34 Politics is about

Making collective decisions in:

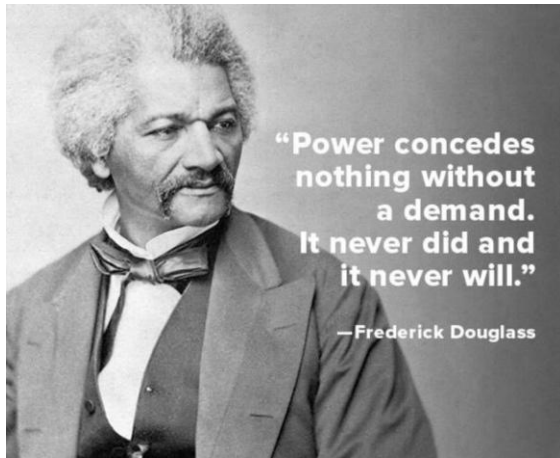
The Coercive Sphere

1.35 Politics is powerful



George Washington

1.36 Politics is powerful



Frederick Douglass

2. Canvas and e-Book Overview

3. Questions

3.1 Next Lecture & Reminders

- **Next class (August 24):** Basic Ethics
- Be prepared to discuss personal ethics
 - What are ethically appropriate uses of physical force (violence)?
 - How do you or should you make ethical decisions?
 - If you have to make a decision affecting the lives or property of others, how do you determine right from wrong?
 - We are not interested in the legal answers, but in the personal ethical answers if the law is not present
- **Following class (August 26):** Begin Constitutional Safeguards

3.2 Upcoming Due Dates (from Syllabus)

- Module 0 substantially complete by **August 30** (avoid drop)
- Module 1 Study Guide and Connect due **September 18**
- Module 1 Quiz – In Class **September 21**

3.3 Authorship and License

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